

Mustafa Alperen Ekinici

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Research: Empirical aesthetics, visual perception, individual differences, deep neural networks, eye movements, EEG, fMRI

Education

Ph.D. in Cognitive Neuroscience

Neural Computation Group, Justus-Liebig-University Giessen

- Supervisor: Prof. Daniel Kaiser

Germany
2024-Current

M.Sc. in Neural and Behavioral Sciences

Max-Planck Institutes for Biological Cybernetics - The University of Tübingen

- Supervisor: Prof. Andreas Bartels

Germany
2021-2023

B.A. in Psychology

Bogazici University

- Supervisor: Prof. Inci Ayhan

Turkey
2017-2021

Research Positions

Max Planck Institute for Biological Cybernetics

Research Assistant

Investigated fMRI responses to the geometric optical flow representation of real scenes in the brain.

Germany
October-December 2023

Max Planck Institute for Intelligent Systems

Research Assistant

Worked on 4D human motion perception using state-of-the-art motion capture techniques.

Germany
December 2021 - July 2023

Skills

- **Programming:** Matlab, Python, jsPsych
- **Methods:** fMRI, EEG, eye tracker, online experiments
- **Analysis:** Decoding/encoding models of cognitive mechanisms, machine learning tools
- **Project management:** Leading independent end-to-end research projects, supervising thesis students

Teaching

- **Teaching Assistant** at JLU Giessen Summer 2025
Neural Computation II - Foundational neural computation methods in cognitive neuroscience II
- **Teaching Assistant** at JLU Giessen Winter 2024
Neural Computation I - Foundational neural computation methods in cognitive neuroscience I
- **Teaching Assistant** at Bogazici University Spring 2021
Introduction to Matlab

Awards

- Travel award at International Association of Empirical Aesthetics (IAEA) 2026

Supervision

- **Xueying Yan** Ongoing master's thesis: The role of aesthetic processing in multisensory integration.
- **Mark Merkouchév** Ongoing internship: The influence of predictability of an image in visual beauty.
- **Melis Akdeniz** Ongoing master's thesis: The part-whole relationship in art perception.
- **Nina Buhlmann** Bachelor's thesis: Modeling aesthetic experiences across the viewing of an artistic film.

Publications

- [1] **M. A. Ekinci**, N. Buhlmann, and D. Kaiser, "From pixels to pleasure: Visual features explain dynamic aesthetic experiences across distinct movie content", *bioRxiv*, pp. 2026-04, 2026.
- [2] **M. A. Ekinci** and D. Kaiser. "Shared gaze reflects shared aesthetic experiences". Preprint. bioRxiv: 2026.01.30.702749. [Online]. Available: <https://doi.org/10.64898/2026.01.30.702749>.
- [3] D. Alashan, D. Tanriverdi, **M. A. Ekinci**, and I. Ayhan, "The effects of abutting pattern motion and smooth pursuit eye movement on the visibility of low-contrast luminance-modulated target gratings", *Journal of Vision*, vol. 21, no. 9, pp. 2634-2634, 2021.
- [4] D. Tanriverdi, D. Alashan, **M. A. Ekinci**, and I. Ayhan, "The effect of target motion and smooth pursuit eye movement on the visibility of isoluminant target gratings", *Journal of Vision*, vol. 21, no. 9, pp. 2619-2619, 2021.